TOP THINGS TO DO IN NAIROBI

1 A visit to the Sheldrick Elephant Orphanage is an eye-opening encounter with African elephants. Started by the late Dame Daphne Sheldrick more than 50 years ago, it has helped save hundreds of elephants and other animals.

2 The Nairobi National Park has plenty of black rhinos to spot in case you didn't see any in the wild. Visit the Ivory Burning Monument here, which marks the spot where former President Daniel arap Moi destroyed poached ivory and banned its trade in 1989.

3 A popular stop for tourists, especially families with kids, is the giraffe centre run by the African Fund for Endangered Wildlife at Langata. Here, you can wait atop a wooden platform with a basketful of special 'biscuits' that are snapped up by these graceful, long-necked wonders.

4 The Nairobi National Museum is a treasure trove of archaeological artefacts, contemporary art, and natural history exhibits.

EAT

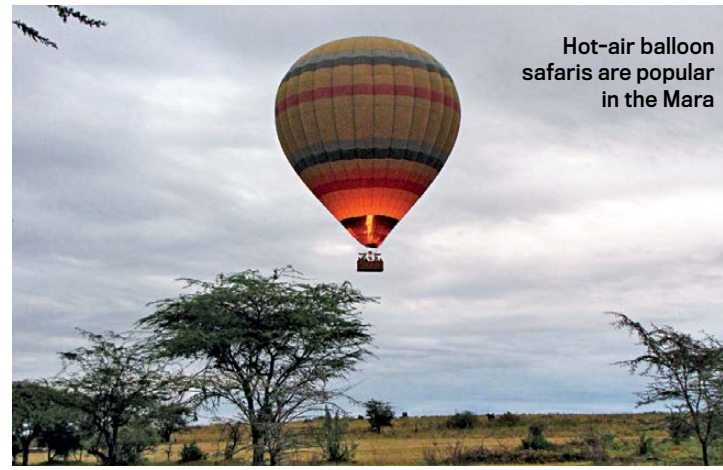
Try the vegetarian cornmeal dish called ugali with a curry and irio (mashed potato, peas, and maize), or the popular grilled goat meat (nyama choma) at a local eatery anywhere in Kenya. Or visit the high-end Jiko in Nairobi's Karen district for elevated Kenyan cuisine. If you're a non-vegetarian and an adventurous eater, a visit to Carnivore in the suburb of Langata might be the ticket. Apart from the usual domestic meats and poultry, there's also farmed ostrich and crocodile.

STAY

Maasai Mara: Muthu Keekorok Lodge, from $410 doubles, muthuhotelsmgm.com | **Aberdare:** The Ark, from $135 per person, thearkkenya.com | **Lake Nakuru:** Lake Elmenteita Serena Camp, from $462 doubles, serenahotels.com | **Nairobi:** Tribe Hotel, from $269, tribe-hotel.com

LOVE

Huge stores along the highways are chockful of factory-made as well as artisanal artefacts, batik and woven fabrics, and sculptures. Even the most restrained shopper will have to give into this onslaught of beautiful buys at some point.



Hot-air balloon safaris are popular in the Mara

PHOTOGRAPH: PRIYA PATHIYAN

living in it, is a UNESCO World Heritage Site. It isn't flamingo season when we visit, but we see hundreds of pelicans, and several giraffes and rhinos.

Royal treatment

The Aberdare National Park is in central Kenya too, only a short drive (127 kilometres) from Lake Nakuru. You immediately feel the crispness of the mountain air as you approach the entrance, from where you can glimpse the Aberdare mountain range. The 766-sq-km park is at an elevation of between 2,000 and 4,000 metres and has diverse topography. We've carried a small bag with essentials for an overnight visit to The Ark inside, which has three decks and lounges with floor-to ceiling glass as well as a ground-level bunker from where you can spend all day (and night) watching animals and birds visiting the watering hole and salt lick right outside.

The Treetops hotel nearby, also inside the Aberdare National Park, is where, in 1952, the late Elizabeth found out she was Queen of England. While I don't receive news on such a phenomenal scale, I do feel like royalty with the sheer access to wildlife viewing in absolute comfort.

The cosy rooms don't have locks and there's a buzzer that's rung in case of wildlife visiting in the middle of the night! We wait to see whether there'll be one ring (for elephant), two (rhino), three (leopard) or four (unusual sightings). And as soon as the first one sounds, we jump out of bed to rush to see a whole herd of elephants congregating for a party. Luckily, the watering hole inside has some delish drinks for wildlife enthusiasts who got thirsty watching the antics at unearthly hours.

Jambo, Nairobi!

It's a three-hour drive from here to Nairobi, the country's capital. We do a pit stop at Nanyuki en route to stand on the Equator. Soon, it's time for the contrasting sights of the city, similar in many ways to Mumbai. Posh areas brimming over with bougainvillea-filled bungalows, business districts that look like they do anywhere in the world, and poor neighbourhoods. The traffic snarls are, if possible, even snarlier than those in Indian cities. But there's a certain rhythm to everything that you soon tune into and get a deeper understanding of the culture beyond the toothy "Jambo!" smiled at tourists at every step.